

Sabotage specialists
The SOE mounted one of its most successful sabotage operations in Nazi-occupied Norway. Norwegian commandos *(above)* were flown in to attack the Norsk Hydro plant at Rjukan, which was producing heavy water that could have been used by the Germans in the manufacture of nuclear bombs. The Webley & Scott 1907 automatic pistol *(right)* was favoured by SOE personnel in many such operations.

Based in London during World War II, the Special Operations Executive (SOE) sent secret agents into Nazi-occupied Europe to support and organize resistance groups, gather intelligence, and carry out sabotage and assassination missions. It was desperately dangerous work and many agents fell into the hands of the SS or the Gestapo. SOE ended the war with some notable successes to its credit, even if it never quite achieved the ambitious goal fixed by Prime Minister Winston Churchill, to "set Europe ablaze".

The Special Operations Executive was set up in July 1940, as an expression of Churchill's determination to take the fight to the enemy even under the most unfavourable circumstances. The defeat of the British and French armies had left Germany and its allies with undisputed military dominance of continental Europe. The British government envisaged nothing less than a continent-wide revolutionary uprising against the Nazis and pro-Nazi regimes. The Minister of Economic Warfare, Dr Hugh Dalton, in whose political domain SOE was placed, foresaw the creation of movements similar to Northern Ireland's Sinn Fein or Mao Ze Dong's Chinese guerrillas and the fostering of "industrial and military sabotage, labour agitation and strikes, continuous propaganda, terrorist acts against traitors and German leaders, boycotts and riots" to thwart Hitler's menace.

RECRUITMENT AND TRAINING

SOE senior staff were recruited in typically British fashion via personal contacts – the "Old Boy" network of former pupils of the top public schools and graduates of Oxford and Cambridge Universities. This does not mean that they were unsuitable or incompetent, although they were sometimes criticized by the more established intelligence services. Colonel Colin Gubbins, for instance, put in charge of SOE training and operations, was an energetic man who had thought in depth about the tactics and strategy of irregular warfare. The organization set up its headquarters at 64 Baker Street, London, and took over country houses around Britain as training centres. Potential agents and other staff were recruited from all walks of life – one of the most effective female agents, Violette Szabo, was the half-French daughter of a south London car dealer. Because agents would have to merge into a foreign country during their missions, language skills were at a premium. Many recruits were, like Szabo, bilingual British citizens with one foreign parent, or foreign nationals, including members of the forces of Allied governments in exile. SOE sought special skills wherever they could be found. Burglars taught agents to pick locks and convicted forgers prepared their false identity papers. At its peak SOE probably employed around 13,000 people, some 5,000 of these as agents in the field.

Initial training concentrated on physical fitness and the use of basic weapons. Candidates were observed to assess their psychological suitability, with plenty of alcohol provided to see how drink might affect their behaviour. Those who made it through the initial stage were sent for commando training in the rugged Highlands of Scotland. There they learned skills such as parachute jumping, the use of explosives for sabotage, and how to kill an enemy with their bare hands – lethal single combat being taught by E A Sykes and W E Fairbairn, formerly of the Shanghai Municipal Police.



WEBLEY & SCOTT 1907 AUTOMATIC PISTOL WITH SILENCER

The final stage of training focused on the basic craft of an undercover agent. This included lessons in the identification of members of various enemy police and security agencies, the operation of a shortwave radio, the use of codes, and resistance to interrogation.